

TECHNICA

2024 Annual Report

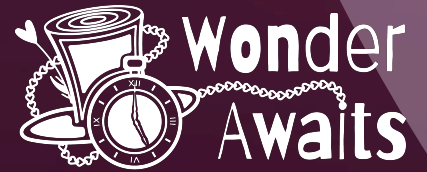


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Letter from the Executive Directors

From the very start, our team at Technica has been guided by our mission to support people of underrepresented genders through their journeys in tech. Although there is still much to be done to reach gender equality, we are proud to say with our 10th year of Technica, we have maintained and increased our efforts to create safe spaces for people of underrepresented genders in tech to learn, grow, and connect with one another.

While our central mission has always been to serve people of underrepresented genders, we at Technica recognize there are many marginalized groups in tech who we can give a proper community to and will continue reaching out to anyone who can benefit. Each year we strive to continue embracing intersectionality, all types of diversity, and being accessible to folks of any needs. We're proud to say Technica 2024 has been one of our most inclusive yet! This season we took great strides to invest in our community through expanding upon our virtual/ hybrid offerings, improving our in-person mentoring initiatives, and conducting more deliberate outreach.

To continue Technica's unique community strengthened, we further built upon our previous virtual experience hosted on Gather. This year, we not only offered a space for virtual and hybrid hackers to interact and learn from each other, we also further developed the space and initiatives to have essentially a second virtual hackathon running with Technica's unique community building experiences, workshops, and project demo-ing. This year, we hosted over 800 hackers, 560 in-person and 89 virtually from across 6 countries and 4 continents! This would not have been possible without our 88 student organizers, __ sponsors, mentors, volunteers, donors, advisors, and alumni. Whether you supported us monetarily, logistically, or by simply cheering us on, we were so thankful for your contribution to Technica this year, and would not have been able to do it without you!

The purpose of this report is to serve as a time capsule for future iterations of Technica to learn from, as well as promote transparency and accountability as an organization. Technica 2024 was certainly a year of trying new things, but also improving upon the best aspects of Technica from years past. We hope you were able to learn and have fun from our event and organization, but most of all, find a community in us that will continue to lift you up when things get hard. Wonder awaits in the next iterations of Technica-- and we're so excited to see how the organization will continue to grow and improve!

We look forward to continuing to grow and strengthen our community of technologists of all walks of life, during Technica weekend and beyond!

With much love,
Erica, Mary, and the Technica 2024 Team



Erica Herrera Huaman
Co-Executive Director



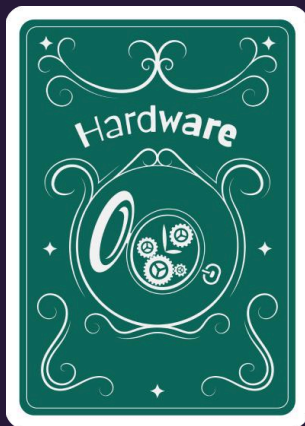
Mary Redpath
Co-Executive Director



Notable Achievements

Strengthening our Technica Community

At Technica, it is very important that we reach and serve as many people of underrepresented genders as possible. This includes people from all walks of life, so this year, we focused on strengthening both local and international communities and trying to form a cohesive community that supports and uplifts each other. We drew from our more local connections and collaborated with numerous UMD clubs this year, including Hack4Impact, App Dev Club, etc., to come up with fun and engaging workshops and projects for our hackers and Technica Fellows. Additionally, we collaborated with our sister hackathon, Bitcamp, as well as other hackathons focused on making a positive impact for underrepresented genders in tech and supported each others community of hackers.



Hardware Track

This year we reintroduced the Hardware Track to encourage participants to explore the fusion of software and hardware engineering. Participants were provided with Arduinos to program and incorporate into their projects. During the hackathon, Hardware Track participants engaged in interactive workshops focused on embedded systems, IoT (Internet of Things), robotics, circuit design, and beyond. This track empowered participants to discover the endless possibilities they can create by integrating hardware and software.

Notable Achievements

Esports

This year, we introduced a new event for hackers in collaboration with the UMD Esports group: a Valorant tournament comprised of two underrepresented-gendered teams between the University of Delaware and the University of Maryland. This initiative stemmed from the increasing tie between the tech and gaming communities. Just like in tech, it's often difficult for people of underrepresented genders to find their place and community in gaming spaces. This event aimed to provide hackers an opportunity to find a common hobby in the tech industry and connect with others who are interested, as well as provide a fun de-stress event for our attendees



Keynote Speakers

We were honored to welcome remarkable speakers to our hackathon to say a few words. Ayodele Odubela, our opening speaker, is the founder of the AI ALT Lab. At the AI ALT Lab, she envisions alternate approaches to AI that prioritize the well-being of marginalized people. She previously worked as a data scientist on auditing HR algorithms, developing ML fairness education at Microsoft, and deploying ML features for various startups. Our closing speaker, Eriol Fox, has been working as a designer for 10+ years in for-profits, NGOs, and open-source software organizations. They work on complex problems like sustainable food systems, peace-building, and crisis response technology. Eriol works at Superbloom on design, research, open-source, and technology projects.



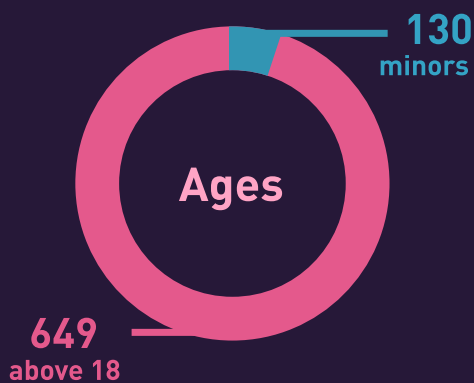
Quick Statistics

650+
Total Hackers

550+ in-person hackers

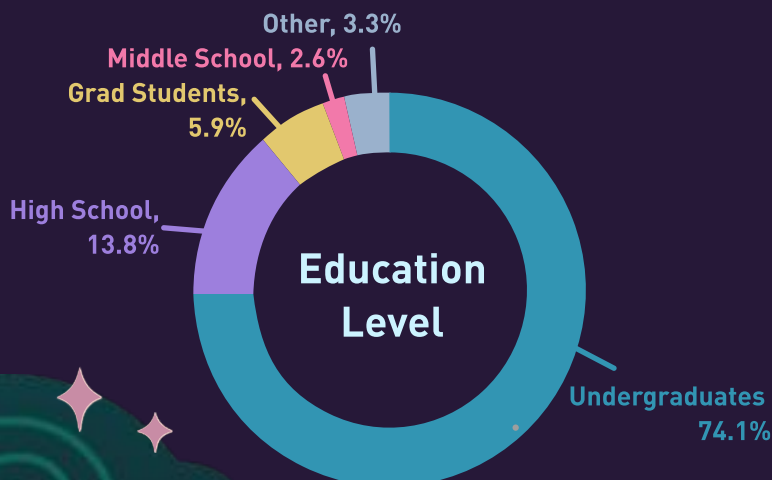
90+ virtual hackers

Hacker Demographics



571 cisgender female hackers	2 transgender female hackers
18 non-binary hackers	3 transgender male hackers
6 genderqueer hackers	? other

Education



Weekend Events

42	Workshops
6	Mini-events
2	Techni-chats (community building events)

Featured Hacks

We gave away

\$4,370

in prizes this year!

Total Projects Submitted

114

of Participants that Submitted a Hack

409

A few of our favorite winning hacks....

Listings

Devpost Link

- [MLH] Best DEI Hack sponsored by Fidelity
- WonderBridge Connecting All Users: Best Accessibility Solution

The Listing App offers a simplified, yet engaging platform to view and save prospective living spaces. Users are able to set their preferences to preemptively filter homes that may or may not align with their search. After completing the initial set up, the application displays the profile of one house at a time providing the user with the option to "heart" the house by swiping right, or "X" the house by swiping left. Once a swipe left has been made, that particular house will not show up again on the users feed.

Users of the app are able to view their "hearted" homes to determine which ones they would like to send to their real estate agent. A send button on each of the living space profiles allows the user to directly message their agent on the app with the link to that space.

Creating an in depth and user friendly experience was important to our team. We wanted the app to be appealing and fun while exuding a sense of calm for those who find home searching stressful. We also wanted to ensure that the home setting page included accessibility filters and community preferences. Our settings page incorporates options such as proximity to schools, restaurants, and queer friendly communities.

Featured Hacks

A few of our favorite winning hacks....

ModSpot

Devpost Link

- Best Startup Track Hack

ModSpot is a cross-referencing program designed to simplify the debugging process for gamers who incorporate mods in their gameplay. Utilizing Windows and Reddit API, the program delivers the user a condensed list of relevant mod filenames that may be the issue.

Explore More



Phoneme Based Augmentative
Alternative Communication Device



Aira



LockedIn



BikeSafe UMD



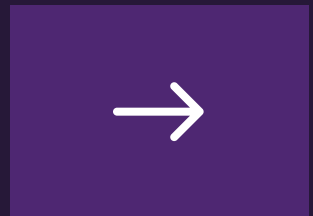
Succession



PLANTrees



TouchGrass



Visit Our Devpost



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Year-Round Community

Regular Community Events

We broadened our influence and made a meaningful impact by organizing frequent events and workshops throughout the year, extending beyond Technica weekend. Our gatherings, which attracted hundreds of attendees both virtually and in person, featured educational initiatives such as introductions to LinkedIn & Networking (in collaboration with Association for Women in Computing), a resume-development workshop, and an insightful panel discussion on Underrepresented Genders in STEM careers. It was a rewarding experience engaging with community members consistently throughout the year!

Summer Fellowship Program

Our fellowship program seeks to make entry into the tech industry easier by offering incoming university freshmen both technical exposure and career guidance. Over the summer, a group of 10 fellows from the local area crafted engaging websites, honing their technical expertise in website development. This process fortified their skill set and instilled confidence in pursuing a career in the tech sector. Fellowship provided them with an excellent platform to showcase their creativity, problem-solving prowess, and collaborative abilities in the realm of website development. In addition to project work, our fellows participated in workshops in collaboration with other on-campus clubs, such as AppDev Club to teach HTML, CSS, and Java to our fellows. We also hosted general workshops for our fellows, such as adjusting to college life, careers in computing, networking and internships, and resume reviews. Beyond the learning sessions, our bonding events and social meet-ups fostered a close-knit community, immersing our enthusiastic students in a supportive environment as they commenced their journeys through both college and the professional world.



Year-Round Community

Fall Big/Little Mentorship Program

In the current year, we revamped Technica's mentorship program, which is designed to offer emerging college students the chance to broaden their network, establish a support system, gain insights from the real-life experiences of mentors and fellow mentees, and develop relevant skills and genuine connections to advance in their professional and academic journeys. With a total of 40 participants from UMD and beyond, each "little" (mentee) was paired with a "big" (mentor), providing guidance on various topics in the tech field and offering professional and career insights. The program commenced before Technica weekend, and big/little pairs continued to meet and grow their mentorship throughout the fall semester, creating a bond that lasts far beyond Technica weekend.

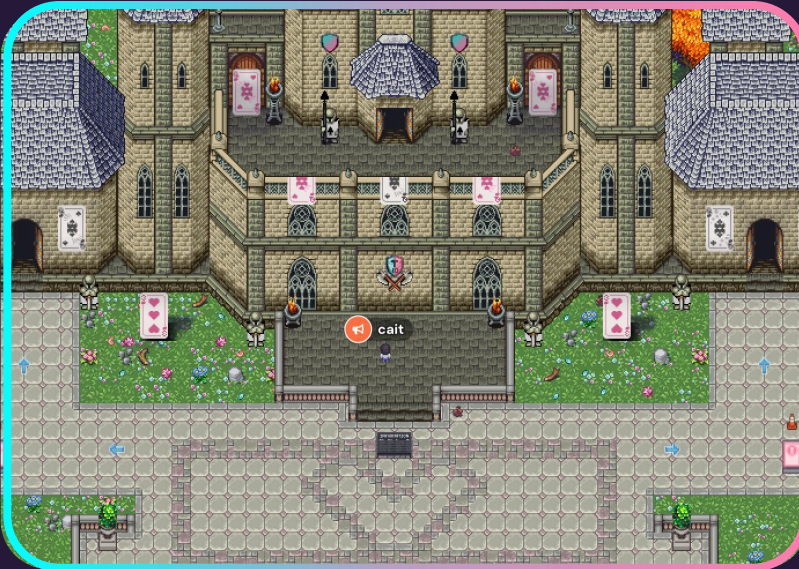
Discord Server and Monthly Newsletter

To create an active community year-round, we actively engaged in monthly events on the Technica Community Discord Server—an online social platform curated for our global community. We also enhanced the Technica newsletter, sending out Technica-related updates and opportunities every month to keep our community aware of current advancements and exciting plans. Our Techni-News consists of insight about upcoming events, program applications, and highlights from our Fellowship and Ambassador cohorts, as well as spreading information about opportunities such as internships, award applications, and other hackathons.



Our Technology

Changes to both our in-person and online event logistics and experience necessitated innovation of our technology. This year, our team launched a suite of custom-built technology solutions designed to support attendees throughout Technica weekend: a custom website and registration form, a custom app with the check-in scanner, and an expo scheduler. We also worked with Gather to create a web-based virtual event platform for those who could not join us in person.



[Click here to visit our Github!](#)

Our Technology team added ReactJS to the tech stack this year, creating an app for the hackers and organizers. This app allowed for an easier check-in experience as well as a portable view of the schedule curated for mobile devices. This year, we continued to use Gather for our virtual hackers, modifying and creating new assets to fit with this year's theme. The team also modified our expo scheduler to assign judges to virtual teams first, before assigning judges to in-person teams. This sped up the judging process while also decreasing the total number of judges needed, as we no longer needed judges both online and in-person at the same time. Improvements were also made to check-in, optimizing it for the app. All of these products were built with our attendees in mind, whether they joined us from home, all around the world, or in person at UMD.

The Team



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The Team



Our Supporters

**Bloomberg
Industry Group**



SOFTRAMS



Qualcomm



T.RowePrice



Connect with Us



Every Donation Counts

Individual contributions also make a huge impact – we appreciate all levels of support!

\$50

The cost to provide electricity and internet to a hacker, so they can stay charged up and logged in all weekend

\$20

The cost of each meal we provide to hackers at Technica, keeping them fueled and properly fed

\$10

The cost per hacker to keep Emergency Medical Services and Security Personnel on hand throughout Technica weekend, just in case

[Donate](#)